

Probation and Performance Review Process

Northgate Group — HR Policy | Version 3.1 | Effective 1 January 2026 | Owner: People Operations

1. Overview

This document describes the probation period for new joiners and the annual performance review cycle that applies to confirmed employees. Both processes are owned by People Operations and administered by line managers.

2. Probation Period

New permanent employees serve a probation period of three months from the start date. During probation the line manager holds a documented check-in at the end of each month covering progress against the objectives set in week one.

At the end of the third month the manager records a confirmation decision: confirm, extend or do not confirm. Probation may be extended once, by up to three months, where more evidence is needed. The decision is communicated in writing within five business days of the end of the probation period. Annual leave accrues during probation but is not normally taken during the first three months.

3. Annual Review Cycle

- January: objectives set for the calendar year and recorded in the performance system.
- July: mid-year check-in, objectives reviewed and adjusted if business priorities have changed.
- November: self-assessment submitted by the employee.
- December: manager assessment, calibration across the department, and the review conversation.
- January: outcomes and any salary or grade changes take effect.

4. Rating Scale

Performance is assessed on a four-point scale: below expectations, meeting expectations, exceeding expectations, and outstanding. Ratings are calibrated across each department before they are communicated, to keep standards consistent between teams. There is no forced distribution.

5. Performance Improvement

An employee rated below expectations is placed on a performance improvement plan of between four and twelve weeks, with specific measurable objectives, agreed support and scheduled review points. People Operations is involved throughout. An employee on a live improvement plan is not eligible for a new remote work arrangement, as set out in the Remote Work Policy.

6. Appeals

An employee who disagrees with a review outcome may appeal in writing to People Operations within ten business days of receiving it. The appeal is reviewed by the department head together with a People Operations representative who was not involved in the original assessment. The appeal outcome is final.